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FEATURES

Cover Your Twenty-Five Miles, Then Rest Up and Sleep

David Cain · Raptitude

On the wall of my office I put up a Tolstoy quote in 32-point text:

A man on a thousand-mile walk has to forget his ultimate goal and say to himself every morning, ‘Today I’m going to cover twenty-five miles and then rest up and sleep.’

I find it much more instructive than the standard “big things happen gradually” clichés: Rome wasn’t built in a day, a thousand-mile journey begins with a single step, how do you eat an elephant (one bite at a time), and the rest.

Tolstoy’s twenty-five miles is like the serious version of those throwaway adages. It’s for the person who genuinely wants (or needs) to cover a thousand miles, rather than just have another way to say “Oh well” after a disappointment. When someone says, “Rome wasn’t built in a day,” it implies that Rome will get built eventually by the way you’re going about things now, but there’s no reason to believe it works like that. Romes don’t get built very often.

Covering twenty-five miles is a serious day’s effort, even though it’s only a tiny fraction of a thousand. It takes a real push, but it is doable, and days like that will add up to vast distances quickly. Note that Tolstoy was talking about hardened French soldiers crossing the Russian steppes; we can scale that twenty-five-mile march down to “A real effort you could achieve daily, but which you’ll only bother with if you’re serious about getting somewhere.”

We should consider bothering with it, because the thousand-mile trek is a thing humans have to do sometimes. They come to us both voluntarily and involuntarily. You might take on an ambitious project, like building an organization or writing a book. Or fate might plunk a long march in front you – cleaning up a huge mess, recovering from serious illness, or paying for some great mistake.

Not built with half-hearted days

For each such trek, the twenty-five-mile day will be something different, but it’s always a day with a clear standard that requires a push to meet it. It might mean spending the first three hours of each weekday drumming up clients until you’re in the black. It might be yet another day of dutifully rehabbing your injury, achieving a caloric deficit, or staying sober.

To make those days happen one after another and eventually get to the end, you can’t stay fixated on the final destination, or you’ll go crazy. Compared to a thousand miles, twenty-five can seem like nothing. You trudged all day in the cold, and the city won’t even be on the horizon for another 960-some miles. Through great effort, you’ve gone an inch when you have to go a yard.

Considered on its own, such a day is really something though – forty of them gets you to a thousand miles. Those

kinds of days (and not even that many of them) really do get the company going, get you to your target weight, or get you past a difficult chapter of life.

Keep your mind on the Motel 6

What Tolstoy is saying is that to have days like that, your focus must stay on this side of the horizon. The prize can’t be out of sight; it has to be reachable today. When your heart is set on a campfire and canned beans end of the day, you can make it. When it’s set on some unseen thing beyond the mountains, your moment-to-moment efforts will be mostly discouraging.

If you joined a gym in January, especially if it’s not for the first time, you may have already discovered this. You cannot sustain a consistent fitness regimen by thinking about how fit you’ll be six months from now. It might help you for the first session. But when it’s day four, and you’re on the treadmill, lungs burning, watching that red digital timer absolutely crawl from 23:00 down to 21:35, imagining some mythical lean version of you is not going to drive you through the next 21 minutes. It might just make you quit.

January on the Russian plains

This is because from the long perspective, there aren’t only 21 minutes left, there are six months left. And nobody can run on a treadmill for six months, certainly not you.

When you make it your goal – i.e. the best thing you can do – to hit your (figurative) twenty-five miles and rest up, your goal becomes thing you can do. It takes effort, but it’s a choice, not a hope.

The ultimate, thousand-mile-away goal remains relevant, but it can mostly be treated as a map and compass, to keep you creating your twenty-five-mile days in the right direction. It’s not the thing you’re aiming at when you’re getting out of bed, or when it’s mile 15 and you want to quit. You’re trying to get to the next camp and enjoy those beans by the fire. You wouldn’t try to do six months of exercise at once with your body, so you shouldn’t try to do it with your mind.

Minard’s famous map of your New Year’s resolution

When I focus on covering the day’s miles and resting up, I get somewhere. When I try to conquer my great personal challenges, I get nowhere. I think the difference is as simple as this: going twenty-five miles is a thing a person can get their mind around, and therefore choose to do, and going a thousand miles isn’t.

So instead of trying to eventually become the person who did the Big Thing, you can immediately become the person who makes their twenty-five miles and rests up for the night.

The rest at the end of the day feels good, but there’s also a hint of healthy disappointment in it. All that marching and your reward is a can of beans. But you can learn to love the

Megasthenes – A Bridge Between the Classical Mediterranean World and Early Imperial India

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Megasthenes, (Μεγασθένης), remains one of the most fascinating bridges between the classical Mediterranean world and early Imperial India: a Greek diplomat, ethnographer and writer who, as ambassador of Seleucus I Nikator, lived at the Mauryan court of Chandragupta and composed what became the first sustained Western account of the subcontinent. Exact details of his birth and upbringing are slim; later sources and modern scholars conventionally place his life in the fourth–third centuries BCE (often cited as born c. 350 BCE and dying c. 290 BCE), and describe him as an Ionian Greek who had served in the eastern satrapies before being dispatched to Pataliputra (modern Patna) in the decades after Alexander’s campaigns.

Terry Bailey explains.

A Bust of Seleukos I Nikator, Bronze, Roman, 100BCE-100CE at the Museo Archeologico Nazionale Naples AN 5590. Source: Allan Gluck, available here .

Megasthenes’ embassy must be read against the turbulent political map that emerged after Alexander: in the 320s–300s BCE the Macedonian successor states and the rising Mauryan power negotiated borders, alliances and exchanges. Seleucus I, having consolidated power in the west and east, sent envoys to the new Mauryan ruler; Megasthenes is usually identified as the Greek who represented Seleucus at Chandragupta’s court, sometime around the opening years of the third century BCE (classical accounts often place the mission in or near 302–300 BCE). While Greek authors disagree about details and chronology, there is broad agreement that Megasthenes lived for a period in Pataliputra and had access to court circles and local informants.

What secured Megasthenes’ long-term reputation was his written work, the *Indica* (Greek: Ἰνδικά) — a multi-book description of India that combined geography, ethnography, political organization, natural history and curious anecdotes. The original *Indica* is lost, but substantial fragments and paraphrases survive embedded in later authors such as Arrian, Strabo, Diodorus Siculus and Pliny; from those citations, scholars have been able to reconstruct large portions of his themes and claims. His account ranged from pragmatic observations, fortified layout and wooden palisades of the Mauryan capital, the scale of rivers such as the Ganges, commercial products, and administrative practices, to more exotic reports (stories of ancient invaders rendered as Dionysus or Heracles, fabulous creatures, and social arrangements unfamiliar to Greeks). The composite picture is of a careful observer who also relied on local informants and existing oral traditions, which accounts for a mix of reliable detail and mythic accretion .

Scholars and ancient critics have long debated how much of Megasthenes to trust. Arrian, the second-century CE

historian who quotes Megasthenes sympathetically, treats him as an important firsthand source; by contrast, Strabo and Pliny accuse him of exaggeration and fantastical reporting. Modern historians tend to take a middle way: many of Megasthenes’ topographical and administrative notes, the scale of Pataliputra, references to markets and ports, the prominence of philosophers in court life, and certain demographic or economic observations, find independent support or at least plausibility, even when his mythic or secondhand claims require skepticism. In short, *Indica* is invaluable as the earliest sustained ethnographic encounter between Greece and India, but it must be handled critically and compared with other evidence.

One important way Megasthenes’ descriptions have been tested is by archaeological work at the site he called Palibothra (Pataliputra). Excavations in the Patna region, notably at Kumhrar, Bulandi Bagh and other spots have revealed extensive Mauryan-age remains: large wooden palisade foundations, signs of monumental timber architecture, and evidence for an unusually large and administratively complex urban center in the third century BCE. Those discoveries do not prove every specific claim in *Indica*, but they corroborate the broad outline of a heavily fortified, sprawling Mauryan capital whose scale and administrative character impressed foreign visitors. When combined with indigenous literary references (Buddhist and Jain texts that mention Pataliputra) the archaeological record strengthens the view that Megasthenes recorded real, observable features of Mauryan urban life .

The composite picture is of a careful observer who also relied on local informants and existing oral traditions, which accounts for a mix of reliable detail and mythic accretion.

George Levrier-Jones

Beyond topography and economy, Megasthenes’ notes on society, his listing of social groups (sometimes translated later as “seven castes” or “classes”), his statements about the role of philosophers and the presence or absence of slavery, and his remarks about trade routes and commodities have been influential (and controversial) in modern reconstructions of early Indian institutions. Some of these formulations reflect Greek categories forcing themselves onto Indian realities; others appear to preserve local administrative distinctions that match evidence from inscriptions and later Indian sources. Thus *Indica* functions simultaneously as an ethnographic snapshot shaped by cross-cultural translation and as a repository of useful data that historians weigh against Indian textual traditions and material finds.

The *Indica*’s afterlife in the classical tradition is also part of Megasthenes’ achievement: later geographers and historians in the Greco-Roman world even when skeptical used his material as the baseline for European knowledge of India

Free Botox

Aea Varfis-van Warmelo · Granta

At some point in my mid-twenties, I refused a doctor's offer of free and regular Botox. My problem wasn't age, or fear of ageing, but one long unending migraine. Botox, the doctor explained, might offer some relief by relaxing the muscles around the head and neck, and by blocking some of the nerve signals volleying between those muscles and the brain.

I sensed, if you can believe it, that I was being fobbed off. This was not, as I saw it, the kind of headache you get from working or frowning or clenching too much. The migraine seemed like something so deep in my brain, stemming from something so deep in my mind, perhaps even my soul, that I instilled in myself a faith that the cure (there had to be one) would have to emerge from something similarly deep.

Chronic daily migraines, as I had gleaned from elsewhere, come from a joy-wreckingly heightened sensitivity in the central nervous system – not merely from tense muscles sending signals along the peripheral nerves. Offering to 'block' it with a bit of nerve toxin sounded like offering to treat a narcoleptic by holding their eyes open with Sellotape. I began to harbour a beady-eyed vigilance to fixes such as these. This had been one of a large number of vaguely stupid-sounding offerings, none of which had worked, and so I resisted. In fact, decided just to do nothing. I would hold out for an experience, revelation – an encounter of sorts. The kind of thing you can't just inject.

I am still – now in my mid-thirties – waiting for this thing. Does that mean I regret not doing the Botox? I remain unconvinced it could have cured me, and still nurse the hope of some profounder, ideally lasting, healing source. But now I wonder more about the other joys that are attributed to the paralysing poison – those I'll likely never know.

I do not mean that I have developed, as my face has started to crease, a greater interest in smoothing it out. Or a greater ease with the idea that women should be expected to sit through and pay for such things. This, had I been so inclined, I might have predicted, and would likely have overpowered my anti-medical sulk. What I mean has to do with what I couldn't have foreseen: the importance, in the new cosmetic era, of having something to say about Botox.

For what I hadn't grasped when the doctor offered to paralyse my skull was that we were entering an age in which the once-niche experience of elective muscle freezing would become a veritable fulcrum of both right-wing and liberal feminist debate, a litmus test of which kind of feminist you are. The kind of girl who is bent on 'resisting' the call to be maximally smooth, hoping thereby to resist the patriarchal-capitalist punishment of female ageing; or the kind who just wants to have fun, and who supports your 'choice' to submit to expensive regimes of facial ironing.

In this new era, commitment to the former camp is a slippery business. Where we might once have understood facial Botox as the embarrassing entertainment of the wealthy and bored, the claims now made on its behalf are nothing less than spiritual, ethical, literary, even.

Botox, I hear, is not just a great way for women to feel 'empowered', but – if the press is to be believed – a 'god-given', 'life-changing', 'alchemical' 'weapon against time' that makes women shine like 'queens'. They say it makes you feel 'gorgeous' – a feeling they describe in a way that makes being gorgeous sound like heroin or crack. So good you might even forget that you are going to die one day, even if you look too young to do so. So good you might start to believe that it was this, and not the right to grow old unpunished, that was fundamentally in women's best interests.

It is hard to argue with those who claim, in beauty terms, to have met God, and still I am moved to try each time the conversation comes up. Hence my wish I had given the Botox just one little whirl – then at least I could have said, with the air of one who knows, Oh I know, but there are bigger things to consider. Or maybe in fact there aren't. In which case it would also have been nice to find out on the NHS.

Image © The New York Public Library

This essay is part of Resistance, a series on Granta.com where writers tell us about a time they have pushed back against change or advice.

The post Free Botox appeared first on Granta.

Ferdinand Magellan: The Man who First Circumnavigated the Globe

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Ferdinand Magellan's name is etched into history as the man who led the first expedition to circumnavigate the globe, an achievement that forever reshaped humanity's understanding of the world. His journey was a story of daring ambition, perilous voyages, and unyielding determination, all undertaken in the age of discovery when maps were incomplete and much of the Earth remained mysterious. Yet Magellan himself would not live to see the full success of his enterprise, perishing before his fleet returned home. His legacy, however, endured as one of the most significant milestones in the history of navigation and exploration.

Terry Bailey explains.

Discovery of the Strait of Magellan (Descubrimiento del Estrecho de Magallanes) by Álvaro Casanova Zenteno .

Magellan was born around 1480 in northern Portugal, likely in the small town of Sabrosa, though the details of his childhood are not fully certain. He came from a noble but not particularly wealthy family and entered the service of the Portuguese court at an early age. As a boy, he was educated in navigation, cartography, astronomy, and seamanship, skills that would later serve him well as an explorer. Like many young men of Portugal's noble class, he became a page at the royal court and soon grew fascinated by the maritime exploits of Portugal's great navigators. Portugal at the time was at the forefront of global exploration, having pioneered trade routes along the coasts of Africa and toward India, and Magellan found himself immersed in this world of maritime ambition.

By his early twenties, Magellan joined expeditions to the East, sailing first to India and later to the fabled Spice Islands, the Maluku archipelago in present-day Indonesia, through the Portuguese route around the Cape of Good Hope. These journeys acquainted him with both the riches of Asia and the complexity of long-distance navigation. Yet his career in Portugal was not without friction. After serving in several campaigns, including military action in Morocco, Magellan fell out of favor with King Manuel I. Denied further command and accused of illegal trading, he turned instead to Spain, Portugal's great maritime rival, to pursue his ambitions.

In 1517, Magellan offered his services to King Charles I of Spain (later Holy Roman Emperor Charles V), proposing an ambitious plan: to reach the Spice Islands by sailing westward, thus avoiding Portuguese-controlled waters in the east. The Spanish crown, eager to break Portugal's monopoly on the spice trade, accepted his proposal. In 1519, Magellan set sail from Seville with five ships, the *Trinidad*, *San Antonio*, *Concepción*, *Victoria*, and *Santiago*, and roughly 270 men. His goal was nothing less than to chart a western passage to Asia.

The voyage was fraught with hardship from the very beginning. Storms battered the fleet in the Atlantic, and crew mutinies tested Magellan's authority. Yet he pressed on, hugging the South American coastline in search of a strait that would lead to the Pacific. For months the fleet explored treacherous inlets until, in October 1520, Magellan discovered the passage that now bears his name, the Strait of Magellan at the southern tip of South America. The narrow, winding waters were perilous, but they opened into an ocean unlike any Magellan had ever seen. He named it the *Mar Pacífico* —the “peaceful sea”—for its calm compared to the turbulent Atlantic he had left behind.

Crossing the Pacific proved far from peaceful for the crew. The crossing was unimaginably vast, lasting over three months without fresh provisions. Many sailors succumbed to scurvy and starvation, chewing leather and sawdust to survive. Yet the fleet pressed on, eventually reaching the islands of Guam and then the Philippines in March 1521. Here, Magellan sought both provisions and an opportunity to convert local rulers to Christianity, aligning with Spain's imperial and religious mission.

It was in the Philippines, however, that Magellan met his end. In April 1521, he became embroiled in a conflict between rival local chiefs. Leading his men into the Battle of Mactán, Magellan was struck down by warriors led by the chieftain Lapu-Lapu. His death was a heavy blow to the expedition, but his men carried on under new leadership. After further hardships and the loss of several ships, the expedition was reduced to a single vessel, the *Victoria*, commanded by Juan Sebastián Elcano. In September 1522, the *Victoria* returned to Spain with just 18 men, completing the first circumnavigation of the Earth.

As Magellan had succumbed to the attack led by the chieftain Lapu-Lapu he naturally did not witness this triumph, but the success of the voyage confirmed what many had only speculated: that the Earth was indeed round and that its oceans were interconnected. The circumnavigation provided crucial new knowledge of global geography. It revealed the staggering size of the Pacific Ocean, recalibrated European conceptions of distance and trade, and laid the foundation for future maritime empires. Spain now had a claim to the Spice Islands and the prestige of sponsoring the first global voyage, though Portugal would contest these claims fiercely.

Magellan contributed more than geography to the world's understanding. His expedition demonstrated the practical possibility of circumnavigation, proving that long-distance navigation could be achieved through careful seamanship, astronomical observation, and the use of advanced navigational instruments such as the astrolabe and quadrant. He and his crew also documented winds, currents, and coastlines that would guide sailors for generations. In terms of society, his journey helped to knit together the world's continents into a global network of trade and cultural exchange, albeit one that was often marked by exploitation and con-

The Complex

Brodie Crellin · Granta

In September 1990 – five years after Sachin and Gita’s return – the family came apart.

It began with Mohit’s participation in the anti – affirmative action protests sweeping the country. Mohit was now eighteen, a fresher in college.

Gita had just returned to A-19 from her work at St. Xavier’s School when she heard that Mohit had been grievously injured at a protest and was in the hospital.

She phoned Sachin at his office. ‘Should we go there?’ she asked. ‘Or will Karishma get angry?’

What had happened was this: A month earlier, in August, India’s prime minister, V. P. Singh, had undertaken a controversial, populist move, pressing into law the Mandal Commission Report, which gave twenty-seven percent reservations in government jobs to ‘other backward castes’ – OBCs. Government jobs were one of the few paths to security and upward mobility in socialist India; and so the upper-caste students – the majority of college students – responded with fury to this affirmative action. As a friend had put it to Mohit: ‘Twenty-two-point-five percent of these jobs are already reserved for untouchables. Now they want to reserve fifty percent. What’s going to be left for us? Is it our fault that we were born upper caste? V. P. Singh is just appeasing minorities to garner their votes.’

In Brij’s house, too, there was surprising agreement on this issue.

The coddling of minorities, Brij felt, had gone too far. Whenever he could, he would quote a newspaper interview he’d read with a rising rustic politician who supported the implementation of the quotas.

But would you go to a doctor who got in on reservation – on affirmative action? a journalist asked the politician.

No, bhaiya , the politician responded. I’d go to America .

The politician was being facetious, but Brij chose to interpret it literally.

Soon after the implementation of the Mandal Commission Report, protests had erupted. Mohit joined them. The upper-caste students shut down colleges, blocked buses, demonstrated in front of hospitals and major intersections, and sat on traffic islands polishing shoes (as an indication of what would become of them), stopping motorists and chatting with them . . . How could merit, they asked, the one source of ‘fairness’ in an unfair country, be stripped from them? (The lower-caste students, if anyone noticed them, huddled silently in the college canteens, their very silence exposing their previously only guessed-at castes.)

Nevertheless, though Brij supported the protest, he was not happy with his son’s participation in it. For all Brij’s strict drill sergeant patrolling of his son’s education over the years, he had failed to turn Mohit into a stellar student. Instead, in class 11 and 12, Mohit had started to boldly rebel, whiling away long hours at the club, playing squash and table tennis, coming back with his clothes stinking of smoke, and interfering whenever Brij tried to discipline Karishma – what did the boy understand of his parents’ relationship? Did Mohit know the humiliations Brij had suffered to collect loans to send Mohit abroad? But now Brij did not feel warmly enough toward his firstborn to grant him his wish of being freed from his father’s gravitational pull. No, Mohit would remain under Brij’s command till he learned to obey, and so now Brij’s strategy, as Mohit had progressed stumbingly toward college, doing worse and worse in class 12 but wanting money to treat his friends and buy rock cassettes, was to make Mohit aware of the money that he , Brij, possessed, while withholding it so that Mohit often stormed off in a rage at being denied even minimal pocket money, shouting, ‘This is why I don’t study, I live in the house of a fateecher,’ and when Karishma tried to intercede on his behalf, Brij would say, with all the force of someone who feels permanently wronged, ‘Enough from you, he has to learn the value of money: Is there one thing he’s achieved? Let him not think that if he goes on like this, we’ll support him,’ and what hurt Brij later, when he turned his mind to the subject of his older son in the privacy of his dark-wood-paneled bedroom, was that he knew Mohit was smart , that he was verbally and mathematically gifted, but was throwing it all away in an act of revolt against the very circumstances – Laxman’s support – that made Brij flush with funds to spend on Mohit.

And Brij knew, too, that Mohit’s rage in public was directed only at his parents. With his Sachin Chacha and Gita Chachi, he could be polite, giving, observant. It had also come back to Brij, via the double-agent Rupvati of course, that Mohit sometimes went over to his Chacha and Chachi’s and asked them about college in the US, was it expensive, what would Chacha recommend, should one go for graduation or for post-graduation, and yet when Brij raised the issue of Mohit’s future with Mohit, he would shout back, ‘Why do you care, I’ll manage it, and it’s not like you went to college,’ and Brij would get up from his sofa-chair in the drawing room, ears burning, and shout, ‘That’s exactly why, you duffer! Do you want to be like me? Fine, we’ll send you into the armed services, we’ll turn you into a man,’ and he would perhaps even have acted on this threat had Karishma not literally thrown herself at his feet and begged him not to sacrifice their oldest child. Then, one day, when Mohit was in class 12, Laxman (always a third party in all of Karishma and Brij’s conversations) had asked Brij, ‘How are Mohit’s studies? He’s in the school cricket team, no? You know, I’m on friendly terms with the vice chancellor of DU.’ Laxman was glowing with power. The BJP had done very well in the 1989 elections – winning eighty-three more seats than in the previous election – and was supporting V. P. Singh’s coalition from the outside, though the party was ambivalent about the Mandal Report.

The Outbreak of World War 1: How Belgium Said 'No' to Germany in 1914

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

We may think that the history of Belgium in 1914 was a long time ago, something that could never happen today. We couldn't be more wrong! Belgium faced intense pressure from a much larger neighbor, a situation that small countries still experience to this day. What makes Belgium stand out is that, given only twelve hours to decide, they didn't cave in, and in doing so, changed history forever. In 1914, Germany had a plan. Step one: march through Belgium. Step two: crush France. Step three: Win the war, or something like that. But they forgot that Belgium might say no. But now on a serious note, during The Great War Belgium was occupied for four years, and that's all because Belgium didn't allow Germany to move troops onto Belgian territory to attack France. But why did they refuse? Germany after all had around seven times more troops than Belgium. Well it boils down to a few reasons.

Kacper Szynal explains.

A Punch cartoon from 1914 showing 'little' Belgium barring 'big' Germany's path.

Why Germany needed to cross Belgium

The Schlieffen Plan required a fast, easy entry into France, which meant invading Belgium, and originally the Netherlands to strike France from their territory and crush them in weeks. Just before the war, the invasion of the Netherlands was scrapped because of Dutch trade neutrality and their trade routes, also because Queen Wilhelmina was a close friend of Kaiser Wilhelm II. The plan was simple: defeat France via Belgium before Russia could fully mobilize. Then, the entire German army could turn east and deal with Russia, a strategy that didn't exactly go according to plan, but that's a story for a totally different article.

Why Belgians Didn't Believe Germany

This is something I often see overlooked. Germany tried to scare Belgium into thinking that France was the threat, by saying that France would attack them, to get to Germany. Of course Belgians didn't take that seriously at all.

Belgium's Neutrality and the Treaty of London

I think that speaks for itself. Belgium, being a neutral country, couldn't just give them military access through their land because that would be seen, not as an attempt at surviving the war, but as a cooperation with the Central Powers. You may ask, what's the problem, a lot of countries are neutral. Yet the problem is Belgium's neutrality wasn't just their choice, it wasn't just their policy, in 1839 Belgium signed the treaty of London, the treaty clearly said that Belgium will become permanently neutral, no matter what. If they would accept the German ultimatum in the worst case scenario where Entente wins, Belgium would cease to exist, because the whole point of Belgium was to be a neutral buffer state between Germany and France. In the best case

scenario, Belgium would become a German puppet, and that's a point we will talk about in a bit.

Germany's Track Record with Occupied Territories

From France's Alsace-Lorraine to Prussian Poland, Germany wasn't keen on returning occupied territories, and allowing them to enter Belgium would be a death sentence for the country. As I said, in the best case scenario, they would become a puppet. And Germans weren't really nice to non-Germans living inside their occupied land. Of course they would never allow something like that so their answer would be always no.

Belgium knew that resisting German occupation would save them

Of course, as I said, Germany had around seven times more active troops. But Belgium knew that if Entente would win the war, Belgium would be restored to full independence, maybe even gaining new territories. It was a bit of a gambit, because if Germany were to win The Great War, Belgium would not only become a puppet, but in the worst scenario would need to pay massive war reparations for not letting Germany in.

Belgians weren't keen on Germans inside their country

I mean, would you want three quarters of a million foreign soldiers inside your small country? And let them attack your neighbor out of the blue? Imagine it like this: Russia or any big power wants to attack Sweden and asks nicely if their army could march through Finland. I don't think anyone in Finland would allow something like that. That's basically what happened in Belgium in 1914. They couldn't just allow something like that.

Belgians thought they could stop the attack

Ok, let's be clear, no, Belgians didn't think that their small army could stop the German advance, but they were promised aid from France and the British Empire if Germany would attack. They thought that they could stop the advance with their help, and well it didn't really go that well, did it?. It was a weird mix of optimism and overconfidence.

Aftermath of Belgians saying no

Now, after knowing why Belgians said no, let's talk about the aftermath of that important decision. Of course the most obvious one, Germany attacked Belgium. They sent the ultimatum on August 2, 1914 at 7pm giving them only 12 hours to respond. After Belgium refused to give them military access, Germany attacked two days later on August 4, 1914. Also because of that declaration of war, the British Empire joined the war, joining the Entente side. But why? Remember the Treaty of London? It didn't only make Belgium neutral, it also guaranteed their borders. The UK, signing that treaty in 1839, wanted to keep the balance of power in Europe; they could have never imagined that 75 years later the same treaty would drag them into the greatest war

African American Servicemen in Britain During World War 2

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Just after 9pm on a cool September evening in 1943, a large group of soldiers calmly walked the mile home to camp where they armed themselves with tommy guns, ammunition and bayonets. Putting themselves into formation, they marched back into town, three-a-breast. The sound of their army-issue boots striking the road for nearly a mile echoed heavily in the pitchy-ink of the blacked-out night-time and is something witnesses remember to this day. It seemed as if a 'whole company' of troops was moving through the night, it was said later.

Here, author Kate Werran tell us about African American servicemen in Britain during World War Two.

In England, Major Charity E. Adams, Columbia, South Carolina., and Captain Abbie N. Campbell, Tuskegee Institute, Tuskegee, Alabama, inspect the first members of the African American Women's Army Corps assigned to overseas service.

Undoubtedly the troops who were on the move were ready for the fight of their lives – it just wasn't the official enemy they had in their sights. Because unbelievably this was not happening in mainland Nazi-occupied Europe, but on Britain's homefront – specifically the market town of Launceston in Cornwall. And these were American soldiers. Military police patrolling the town could sense impending danger. 'Everything was so tense that evening that we thought that something might start,' said one. Another added that all evening '...you could feel the tenseness in the air.' Even publicans working in the town's many drinking houses felt this was the calm before the storm. One shut early that evening saying how he just sensed '...something brewing.'

Suddenly the marching troops appeared 'in a body' from out of the darkness to encircle a group of military policemen, fellow Americans, who were standing chatting next to a jeep parked near the town's war memorial. 'We saw forty to fifty soldiers coming up the street. They had overcoats on. They walked up almost in formation, and straight toward us... and [we] thought trouble was about to begin,' said one of the surrounded. A man, who seemed to be spokesman for the group, said very quietly: 'Why don't you let us come into town, come into the pubs?'. Flashlights snapped on. 'Hands up!' was shouted. The military police raised their arms and backed up. As they did, 'I heard bolts open on rifles,' said the jeep's driver. There was just time for the terrifying realisation to sink in that their compatriots were not only armed but already taking aim when: 'I heard a bolt crack and a shot landed at our feet. Someone hollered 'DUCK'. I jumped in behind the wheel of a jeep.' Next, a volley of fire. 'I felt a bullet whizz past me.' A flashlight revealed a soldier 'with a denim hat and overcoat firing a rifle from the hip and he was really pumping them out.' A pause. Then chaos as British soldiers, civilians, WAAFs and Land Army girls, as well as the Americans under fire, scrambled for cover amid

ricocheting bullets. One old man told the Daily Mirror the next day: 'There hasn't been anything like this since the days of the smugglers.'

No-one knows for sure exactly how many soldiers were armed and fighting that night. What is universally acknowledged is a large number was involved – from the 581st Ordnance Ammunition Company who were firing at soldiers from the 115th Infantry's Second Battalion. It was all over in five minutes before the shooters melted away into the night. What they left behind was a shot up town centre, soldiers and citizens shaken, store windows in shatters, two hole-ridden US army jeeps (it subsequently took 20 soldiers to lift them bodily away), two sergeants with mashed-up legs, the visiting US army with its reputation hugely-dented and bullet holes in Cornish bricks and mortar which for more than seventy years were the sole reminder of an all-American gunfight army authorities wanted forgotten and tried their best to obscure. Because the inconvenient truth here was that these were members of an African American ordnance company who were taking on the white soldiers who policed them. The level of injuries given the firepower on hand that night shows precisely that wholesale slaughter was certainly not the intent, although military prosecutors defied their own investigators recommendations and insisted on bringing attempted murder charges alongside mutiny et al. The 'mutineers' were making a point and it was one that was needed to be made.

African American servicemen

There were around 130,000 African Americans among the 1.5 million US servicemen who were in the United Kingdom at any one time in World War Two – altogether 4 million Americans would come to Britain. But this segregated army had an inherent racial friction which began to spill over into violence with increasing frequency whenever the two races met in Britain's 'green and pleasant' land. Riding on the tide of simmering racial tension in US training camps and explosive riots in five American cities during the long hot 'bloody' summer of 1943, this enmity inevitably floated across the Atlantic with each wave of arriving servicemen.

At first it baffled the British. Despite ruling an empire upon which 'the sun never set' there were surprisingly few people of colour, roughly 15,000, in Britain during World War 2. Undoubtedly, in such a mono-cultural society, racism was bound to thrive as proved by race riots in 1919 and exemplified by the experiences of Learie Constantine, the West Indian cricketer, who came to live in Britain in the 1920s and described how 'personal slights' were 'an unpleasant part of life in Britain for anyone of my colour.' But evidence from thousands of censored letters, secret reports from the Ministry of Information's Home Intelligence division, surveys for Mass Observation (the nascent polling organisation) as well as editorials and letters to newspapers and government departments shows this confusion amongst ordinary Brits soon morphed into outright rejection of the 'colour bar' – and decided support for African American troops. From George Orwell who kicked off his first article for Tribune with "The general consensus of opinion seems to be that

Just How did Settlers to the West and Midwest Survive?

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

The promise of a better life pledged by advertisements created after mid-1800s events in the United States such as the Homestead Act of 1862 – which offered 160 acres of government-owned land in the Midwest and West for free with the possibility of eventually owning the land outright – did not always become the reality.

Those who took advantage of the opportunity afforded by the act to head to the largely rural Midwest and West faced multiple, likely unexpected obstacles, making survival much more difficult than many of them probably imagined. How did those who made the trek survive? Janel Miller offers some answers in this short piece.

The saying “Necessity is the mother of invention” is attributed to Plato in 380 B. C. However, it was just as relevant after 1862 when many left their homes in the East to pursue the promise of a better life in the West.

These settlers faced dry and arid conditions that were previously unknown to them. They responded by using newly developed windmills, irrigation systems and drought-resistant crops. Others found ways to enhance existing techniques, such as manufacturing plows with steel and assembling grain into easy-to-transport bundles.

Still other settlers aggressively sought to have the railroad, then in its infancy, come through their town. Those who succeeded in this endeavor gained easier access to food, animals and other goods necessary to endure.

In addition, many settlers worked with their peers to establish organizations, such as Granges, that succeeded in adding agriculture into school curricula, establishing rural mail delivery and the parcel post system.

The time period covered by this essay has long since passed, but there are still people who desire rural living. The reasons newer generations cite for leaving urban life for a more rural one include a desire for recreational areas and a more affordable cost of living.

Most parts of the United States today offer their residents luxuries such as cell phones, computers and vehicles that the settlers of the American West could likely never have imagined. All the more reason those living today should be in awe of how settlers found ways to survive when they moved to the Midwest and the West.

Did you find that piece interesting? If so, join us for free by clicking here .

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How the U.S. Civil War Made Christmas a National Holiday

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

We take for granted that the Christmas Season entails children are home from school, festive meals are being prepared, airports are crowded as people rush home to their families and parties are in full swing, all in anticipation of the jolly old elf Santa Claus's arrival. Not many people realize though that all of those traditions have their origins in the Civil War.

Lloyd W Klein explains.

The religious nature of the holiday season upon us aside, this time of year has been a time of celebration and gift giving for centuries. The Twelve Days of Christmas and many other traditional songs, as well as Dickens's Christmas Carol, show that this is a celebration time that goes way back in the European culture. This week we are going to trace how the Civil War led to the making of Christmas as a secular, national holiday.

Unsurprisingly, the story is at base a political one. On Christmas Day 1861, President Lincoln chose to host a party at the White House. It was a crucial political moment because Mr Lincoln had a brewing international crisis that he had to stop before it got out of hand.

On Christmas Day 1862, the country was in a national panic. Setbacks in the war had made it anything but a happy season. On this day, Mr and Mrs Lincoln did something that seems so much a part of the responsibility of the POTUS on this holiday that its astounding that it hasn't always been traditional. And on Christmas in 1863, the Lincoln's made yet another gesture of good will to the soldiers in the field.

In 1861 President Lincoln sought to limit an international crisis by throwing a Christmas Party at the White House. The Trent Affair had led to the capture of the appointed Confederate representatives to Britain and France, John Slidell and James Murray Mason. War clouds had started to collect as the British Prime Minister insisted that the US had no right to capture these men on open seas. The capture occurred on November 8 and had become an international scandal after November 18. By Christmastime, there were rumors of British preparations for war and also significant diplomatic efforts were in progress. There were rumors of an invasion from Canada. So, there was a lot for Lincoln to "soft shoe" that day.

In 1862, the Lincoln Family began a tradition to counter the public effects of The Battle of Fredericksburg, which had been a military disaster that spawned a political and public relations catastrophe. "What will the country say?" Lincoln asked. But the POTUS was a political mastermind, and he turned crisis into opportunity. The Lincolns pointedly went the various hospitals around Washington and visited and spoke with the wounded. No president had ever done this before. It showed that Lincoln the commander in chief was a sensitive leader who felt the people's pain.

The hospital visits were so popular, and so necessary, that Lincoln continued them. He brought his son Tad with him on many such days. Tad was deeply moved by the soldiers. So on Xmas 1863, wounded soldiers received gifts of books and clothing from the White House, with a covering note that said, "From Tad Lincoln".

And in 1864, General Sherman telegraphed Lincoln on December 22, 1864 announcing the capture of Savannah. By 1865, as the image above shows, Christmas was a celebration of victory in the war.

The soldiers on the battlefield were far away from home, many had never been outside their county in their lives let alone their state. Union soldiers used salt pork and hardtack to decorate Christmas trees. Others were treated to special meals; a captain from Massachusetts treated his soldiers to foods such as turkey, oysters, pies, and apples; Singing carols was popular, ones that remain popular today, but Christmas cards would not become popular until the 1870s.

When we fly or drive home to Grandmothers House for Christmas, the origin of that tradition is the Civil War. Fathers on both sides of the war were often given furloughs to return home for the holiday.

Christmas originates with a significant religious meaning and yet it has become secular in its celebration. Almost no one knows that this trend began in the Civil War. And even more surprising to many, without Thomas Nast, Christmas as we know it probably wouldn't exist. But Nast wasn't interested so much in Christmas. He was interested in a much bigger issue.

Nast was a cartoonist for Harper's Weekly during the Civil War. If Nast wasn't so interested in Christmas, why the recurrent theme? The 2 Nast cartoons depict Christmas experiences during the war. Identify the subjects of each and what was groundbreaking about them.

The fact is that Nast was a first class political cartoonist who was a Union sympathizing propagandist using Christmas to draw on the emotions of the season to bring the country together.

In the top cartoon, "Christmas Eve" (1862), a wreath frames a scene of a soldier's praying wife and sleeping children at home; a second wreath frames the soldier seated by a campfire, gazing longingly at small pictures of his loved ones.

Another illustration features Santa in his sleigh, then going down a chimney, in the top left of the cartoon. Somber scenes below remind of a grimmer reality—an army marching through snow and a row of frozen graves that refers to the Union's recent failure to take Fredericksburg. But there is hope: Santa is coming!

the January 3, 1863 issue of Harper's Weekly, Nast has an early caricature of Santa dressed in an American flag, with a puppet with the name "Jeff" written on it, Nast was inspired

Michael Ovitz: The Psychology of Power

Vicky · Farnam Street (fs.blog)

Michael Ovitz co-founded CAA and helped reshape Hollywood, then took the same playbook into tech investing and advising founders.

Featured clips

8:17

33:28

43:42

52:49

The Genius of Patrick Collison

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In this conversation, he breaks down the operating rules that kept CAA from losing clients, and the personal disciplines that kept him grounded when the stakes got massive.

You'll learn how to build momentum, tell the truth without hesitation, read for context instead of noise, hire people who raise the standard, and package ideas into outcomes.

“Mediocrity to me is a disease that you have to get rid of at all costs.”

“Momentum to me is the single most important thing in anything we do.”

“Knowledge is power, and it works for you and against you.”

“If you can't tell me what your business is about in 20 seconds, you should not do your business.”

“Power is fleeting and it doesn't last. And if you don't believe that, take a look at anyone that's had it.”

Learn from the mistakes of others.

Don't fight your job.

“I didn't go into business to win a popularity contest. I went into business to win.”

Trust is the most important thing. Betrayal is indefensible under any condition.

Excellence is about standing out, doing good things, and helping people.

Be deeply read in your field and widely read outside it.

“Mediocrity is invisible until passion shines a light on it.”

“I have been viewed by a lot of my friends as the world's best friend and the world's worst enemy because I'm just black and white loyal.”

Tell everyone the truth.

“I don't believe there's any room for competition. They have to be eliminated.”

If someone you respect tells you to meet someone, meet them.

When people confront you, you have to respond. If you don't, people will walk all over you.

Don't believe your press—good or bad. The same people who praise you will later bury you.

People tend to deceive themselves. Never get high on your own supply.

“All we have is our time, and you run out of time very fast.”

People appreciate honesty more than you think.

How you talk about people when they're not around tells everyone what you'll say about them when they're not around.

Arrogance is self-sabotaging.

A good idea taken too far is a bad idea.

“The most important people on the planet are journalists and editors.” They direct our attention.

“I don't agree with people that sit and read things cover to cover because you can't equally weight everything between the covers.”

“I think that momentum is about extraordinarily hard industrious work. It's about deeply educating yourself in your field, deeply educating yourself in the peripheries of your field, knowing who your competitors are.”

The post Michael Ovitz: The Psychology of Power appeared first on Farnam Street .

“I don’t believe there’s any room for competition.”

Vicky

U.S. Civil War Hero of Gettysburg: Lawrence Chamberlain CMH

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Joshua Lawrence Chamberlain stands as one of the most compelling figures of the American Civil War, not because he was a professional soldier forged in a lifetime of military service, but because he was an intellectual and educator who rose to extraordinary leadership when history demanded it. Born on the 8th of September, 1828 in Brewer, Maine, Chamberlain grew up in a deeply religious and disciplined household. His father, a stern militia officer and shipbuilder, instilled in him a sense of duty and moral responsibility, while his mother encouraged learning and faith. Chamberlain excelled academically, displaying a gift for languages and scholarship that would define his early life. He attended Bowdoin College, where he studied theology and the classics, eventually becoming fluent in multiple ancient and modern languages. By the late 1850s, he was a professor of rhetoric at Bowdoin, seemingly destined for a quiet life of scholarship rather than war.

Terry Bailey explains.

Joshua Chamberlain.

The outbreak of the Civil War in 1861 profoundly unsettled Chamberlain. Though opposed to slavery and deeply committed to the Union, he initially remained at Bowdoin, torn between his academic responsibilities and what he saw as a moral obligation to serve. In 1862, he resolved the conflict decisively. Despite lacking formal military training, he requested a leave of absence to join the army, telling Bowdoin's president that the war represented a struggle for the soul of the nation. He was commissioned as a lieutenant colonel in the 20th Maine Volunteer Infantry, a regiment composed largely of lumbermen and farmers, many of whom were older and physically tougher than their scholarly officer. Chamberlain won their respect not through bluster or harsh discipline, but through fairness, shared hardship, and a willingness to listen, qualities that would later prove critical under fire.

By the summer of 1863, Chamberlain had risen to command the 20th Maine, and his regiment found itself marching into history at Gettysburg. On the 2nd of July, 1863, the second day of the battle, the Union Army hastily extended its left flank to anchor on a rocky hill known as Little Round Top. The position was vital; if Confederate forces seized it, they could roll up the Union line and potentially decide the battle in their favor. The 20th Maine was placed at the extreme left of the Union position, with orders that could not have been clearer or more ominous: "Hold this ground at all hazards." There would be no reinforcements. If the regiment broke, the Union flank would collapse.

Throughout the afternoon, Chamberlain's men endured repeated assaults by the 15th Alabama and other Confederate units under Colonel William C. Oates. The fighting was close, chaotic, and brutal, conducted over boulders and through dense woods in sweltering heat. Each Confederate

attack pushed closer to breaking the Union line, and Chamberlain was forced to stretch his regiment dangerously thin, bending his line back like a door hinge to prevent being flanked. Ammunition ran dangerously low. Men collapsed from exhaustion and heat. Chamberlain himself was everywhere along the line, steadying his soldiers, issuing calm orders, and absorbing the terror of combat without losing command of the situation.

As the final Confederate assault loomed, Chamberlain faced a grim reality. His regiment was nearly out of ammunition, and another attack would almost certainly overwhelm them. In that moment, he made one of the most audacious tactical decisions of the war. Rather than waiting passively to be overrun, Chamberlain ordered a bayonet charge. With a sweeping wheel to the left, the 20th Maine surged downhill, shouting and driving their bayonets into stunned Confederate troops who expected no such move from an exhausted and depleted enemy. The sudden offensive shattered the momentum of the Confederate attack. Many Southern soldiers were killed, wounded, or captured, and the rest fled. Little Round Top was held, the Union flank was saved, and the outcome of the Battle of Gettysburg and arguably the war itself tilted decisively in favor of the Union.

Chamberlain's actions at Gettysburg would later earn him the Congressional Medal of Honor, awarded in 1893. The citation recognized his "daring heroism and great tenacity" in holding Little Round Top against overwhelming odds. Yet the significance of his conduct lay not only in bravery, but in leadership and judgment under extreme pressure. Chamberlain demonstrated an intuitive understanding of morale, terrain, and timing, proving that decisive leadership could compensate for material disadvantage. His conduct became a textbook example of initiative at the tactical level, studied by soldiers long after the war. Chamberlain's wartime service did not end at Gettysburg, and the war would exact a terrible physical toll on him. He was promoted to brigadier general and continued to serve with distinction in the Overland Campaign of 1864. At the Battle of Petersburg, he was shot through the hip and groin, a wound so severe that he was expected to die. Grant promoted him on the battlefield as a final honor, but Chamberlain survived after months of agony and recovery. He returned to duty despite chronic pain and lasting disability, embodying the same determination that had defined his stand on Little Round Top.

In one of the war's most symbolic moments, Chamberlain played a prominent role at its conclusion. On the 12th of April, 1865, he was selected to command the Union troops receiving the formal surrender of the Confederate Army of Northern Virginia at Appomattox. In a gesture of reconciliation rather than triumph, Chamberlain ordered his men to salute the defeated Confederates as they laid down their arms. The act reflected his belief that the war had been fought to preserve the Union, not to humiliate the South, and it earned respect from former enemies, including Confederate General John B. Gordon.

After the war, Chamberlain returned to civilian life but never escaped the shadow of his service. He became pres-

Major General Lewis “Lew” Wallace

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Lew Wallace was the youngest Major General in the Union Army at the time of his appointment early in the Civil War, which is especially interesting since he never went to West Point. His father was a lawyer and served as Governor of Indiana, while his grandfather was a Circuit Court judge and congressman. Born in Indiana in 1827, Wallace possessed natural talents in writing and drawing. Although he studied law and briefly served as a second lieutenant during the Mexican War, he did not see any action. Subsequently, he ventured into various pursuits such as publishing a newspaper, practicing law, organizing a Zouave unit militia, and being elected as a state attorney. However, his book did not achieve success.

Lew Wallace wrote *Ben Hur*, the best-selling American novel of the 19th century, and its success made him a wealthy and internationally famous man. Years earlier, he had been an acclaimed war hero and the youngest major general in the Union Army, before losing his command when blamed for the near disaster at the Battle of Shiloh. Wallace would devote much of his life to trying to clear his name of that charge.

Lloyd W Klein explains.

Lewis Wallace.

The outbreak of the Civil War brought about significant changes in Wallace's life. As a staunch supporter of the Union, he switched his party allegiance and demonstrated exceptional skills in recruitment. Lew Wallace commanded the Indiana Zouaves, 11th Indiana Regiment Infantry. The 11th Indiana Infantry Regiment was organized at Indianapolis on April 25, 1861, for a three-month term of service, then reorganized and mustered in for the three-year service on August 31, 1861, with Col. Lewis Wallace as its commander. He served as Indiana's adjutant general and eventually assumed command of a regiment, despite lacking formal military education. In June 1861, he led a successful skirmish, resulting in his promotion to brigadier general and the command of a brigade.

Although he did not participate in the battle, he was entrusted with the command of Fort Henry by General Henry Halleck as the Union advanced towards Fort Donelson. Despite Grant's orders to remain on defense, Wallace took the initiative to launch a counterattack, preventing the enemy from escaping and reclaiming lost ground. His actions during the Battle of Fort Donelson earned him a promotion to major general at the age of 34.

Wallace commanded a brigade of volunteers at the Battle of Fort Donelson in Tennessee in February 1862. After his initiative and boldness had helped secure the Federal victory and the capture of the entire Confederate army there, he was promoted to major general, making him the youngest major general in the Federal army.

Shiloh (April 6–7, 1862) was the place where Grant and Sherman came into their own, but it was almost the end of their careers. PGT Beauregard planned a surprise advance and attack at Pittsburg Landing, on the west bank of the Tennessee River. Exactly how involved Albert Sidney Johnston's role in the planning of the battle has been a subject of controversy. Larry J Daniel argues that Johnston was ill-equipped for the task and lacked the necessary skills.

The northern newspapers exaggerated the nature of the surprise at the time. Although there was no entrenchment, Sherman had received prior warning and some elements of the army quickly discovered the southern lines. Despite facing early setbacks, Sherman displayed remarkable tenacity and skill, proving to himself and others that he possessed the emotional and cognitive abilities required to lead an army.

At the time of the battle, Brigadier General Lew Wallace commanded a division under Major General Grant. On April 6, 1862, Confederate forces under Albert Sidney Johnston launched a surprise attack against Grant's army near Pittsburg Landing, Tennessee. Wallace's division was stationed several miles away at Crump's Landing, north of the battlefield. When the Confederate attack began, Wallace received orders to move his division to support the Union line.

Grant claimed he ordered Wallace to take a specific route that would bring him directly into the Union right flank. Wallace, however, had already set off on a different route—one that made more sense based on the situation earlier that morning and where Union forces had been positioned. Wallace's division was at Crump's Landing, five miles north of the Union line at the start of the battle. When the battle opened, Grant took his steamboat, *Tigress*, south to Crump's Landing, where he ordered Wallace to prepare his division to move, but did not specify the route to be taken.

Wallace did not initiate the movement of his division until noon. He then marched his forces towards Sherman's location, utilizing a road near the river. At 2:00 pm, a messenger informed Wallace that he had taken the wrong road. Wallace believed that he was supposed to reinforce Sherman and McClernand at their original camps, unaware that these divisions had been pushed back towards Pittsburg Landing. Consequently, Wallace found himself behind enemy lines and had to retrace his steps. As a result, he did not arrive on the first day of the battle.

He was eventually ordered to turn back and take another route, which cost several hours. His division did not arrive in time to participate in the fighting on the first day of the battle.

Much of the responsibility for the near disaster at Shiloh was pinned on Wallace. As the battle unfolded, commanding general U. S. Grant ordered Wallace to bring his men to the front. Unaware that the Federals had been driven back from their original position, Wallace took the road leading to where they had been before the battle began. Once he learned that the road he was on was taking him

Here's how to live: Be a famous pioneer.

Derek Sivers

Nobody had ever run a mile in under four minutes.

It seemed impossible.

But one day, Roger Bannister did it, and the news spread worldwide.

Over the next two years, thirty-seven people also did it.

This is the power of the pioneer:

To enable the impossible.

To open a new world of possibility.

To show others that they can do it too, and take it even further.

Explorers used to find unknown lands and bring back stories of unfamiliar cultures, which encouraged others to go exploring.

The old finish line becomes the new starting line.

Debussy, Charlie Parker, Jimi Hendrix, and Rakim pioneered new approaches to music.

Rosa Parks, Harvey Milk, Sally Ride, and Malala Yousafzai broke the glass ceiling, encouraging others to rise.

Modern explorers like Tim Ferriss, Neil Strauss, and A. J. Jacobs, instead of finding unknown lands, are finding unknown lifestyles.

Each of them shows new possibilities for the rest of us.

These pioneers were valuable because they got famous.

If someone else innovated in obscurity, they didn't make an impact.

Marco Polo wasn't the first European to reach China, but he was the first to write a book about it. Then his book inspired Christopher Columbus, and so on.

Millions of young adults today are living a life their grandparents didn't know was possible.

They have more options, thanks to the brave adventures of a few people who broke through boundaries.

Pioneers have a massive impact on the world because their stories help people do things they wouldn't have dreamed of otherwise.

A famous pioneer does more for human progress than a billion others who live a normal life.

So if you want to help humanity while having the most exciting life, then the way to live is to be a famous pioneer.

Go to new extremes.

Try new ideas.

Visit undiscovered cultures.

Show what can be done.

Your job is not just to act, but to tell a fascinating story of how you did so, and inspire others to do it.

Make great adventures, but tell greater stories.

Pursue massive media attention, not for vanity or ego, but so your stories can open minds, spark imaginations, and lead to further explorations.

Here's the best way to do it:

First, make a stage name.

Create a company with the same name, and have it own all the rights to everything you do.

Never reveal your real name.

This is to manage the trappings of your upcoming fame.

Find a writer and a publicist to create your first pioneering adventure.

Collaborate with the writer to make a great story arc before you begin.

So, for example, it's not just a story of how you escaped a cult, but how you joined the cult, uncovered a surprising history, fell in love, were almost discovered and captured, then escaped by changing the mind of your captor, and finally learned some interesting counter-intuitive lessons along the way.

Consult with the publicist to make sure it's interesting to the media.

Then begin.

Record everything on video.

Find ways to make the story arc happen in real life.

When you're done, have your writer make it a fascinating story of various lengths for various outlets — making it a great article, book, video, screenplay, stage talk, and more.

Have the publicist get it everywhere — on every popular platform of the day.

Hire a business manager to turn the attention into profit.

Keep half of your profits in the business, and put half into

Keep half of your profits in the business, and put half into your private savings.

Derek Sivers

Vitus Jonassen Bering – Explorer of Siberia and Alaska

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Vitus Jonassen Bering remains one of the most compelling figures of the great age of exploration, a navigator whose journeys helped redraw the world's map and whose legacy continues to shape the understanding of the northern Pacific. Born in 1681 in the small Danish town of Horsens, Bering grew up in a modest family but showed early ambition and aptitude for a life at sea. Denmark in the late seventeenth century was deeply connected to maritime trade and naval service, and like many young men of his region, Bering was drawn to the ocean. He entered naval service in his teens and soon began to sail widely, developing both technical skill and intellectual curiosity.

Terry Bailey explains.

A depiction of Vitus Bering's expedition being wrecked on the Commander Islands in 1741.

Vitus Bering's decision in 1703 to join the Russian Navy, then being rapidly modernized by Peter the Great, proved the turning point of his life, opening the door to one of history's most consequential careers in exploration. Bering first gained the confidence of the Russian court through disciplined service and steady competence in naval operations, particularly during the Great Northern War. By the 1720s, Russia's ambitions had shifted toward the vast, unmapped territories of Siberia and the Pacific. The question of whether Asia and North America were connected by land remained one of the great geographic uncertainties of the era. In 1724, Peter the Great authorized what became known as the First Kamchatka Expedition, placing Bering in command. His mission was deceptively simple: travel across Siberia, build ships on the remote Kamchatka Peninsula, and set sail eastward to determine the relationship between the continents. The sheer logistical scale of this undertaking, thousands of kilometers of wilderness, extreme climates, and complex local interactions made it one of the most ambitious scientific programs of the eighteenth century.

The First Kamchatka Expedition lasted from 1725 to 1730 and tested every skill Bering possessed. After an arduous overland journey from St. Petersburg to Okhotsk, he supervised the construction of the small vessel Saint Gabriel and, in 1728, sailed north along the coast. Bering's most significant achievement during this voyage was his passage through what is now the Bering Strait, the narrow channel separating Asia from North America. Although he did not sight the coast of the American continent itself, fog and distance prevented the definitive moment, his careful observations confirmed that no land connection existed and that a navigable waterway separated the two continents.

This conclusion, though at the time somewhat understated, had enormous global implications, refuting long-held cartographic myths and opening new horizons for exploration, trade, and scientific inquiry. His success led to an even more

ambitious undertaking: the Second Kamchatka Expedition, or Great Northern Expedition, launched in 1733. This was one of the largest scientific expeditions ever mounted, involving thousands of personnel, multiple ships, naturalists, cartographers, and scholars. Its purpose was nothing less than the comprehensive mapping of Russia's vast northern and eastern frontiers and the full exploration of the Pacific coasts of Siberia and the North American continent. Under Bering's command, the expedition produced some of the most detailed charts of the Arctic coastline to date and enriched science with vast collections of biological, geological, and ethnographic data. It also laid the foundations for Russia's later commercial presence in Alaska, expanding European knowledge of the region's peoples, fauna, and natural resources.

Ill, exhausted, and suffering from what was likely scurvy, Bering died on the island in December 1741.

George Levrier-Jones

The pinnacle of Bering's exploratory achievements occurred in 1741, when he and Aleksei Chirikov each commanded vessels on a voyage east from Kamchatka. During this journey, Bering sighted the southern coast of Alaska, while Chirikov made landfall separately on the Alexander Archipelago. These discoveries confirmed the existence of a large North American landmass far to the northwest, ending centuries of speculation. Along the Alaskan coast, Bering's crew collected valuable geographical information and encountered wildlife unknown in Europe, including the now-extinct Steller's sea cow, first documented by the expedition's naturalist, Georg Wilhelm Steller. The scientific material gathered during this voyage—flora, fauna, coastal descriptions—became an enduring contribution to European knowledge of the Pacific world.

Yet Bering's later life was marked by hardship. On the return voyage from Alaska, his ship, the Saint Peter, was wrecked on what would later be named Bering Island. There, in the treacherous winter of 1741–1742, the stranded expedition struggled to survive. Ill, exhausted, and suffering from what was likely scurvy, Bering died on the island in December 1741. His companions buried him in the sands above the beach, and only in the twentieth century did archaeological excavations uncover what are believed to be his remains. Studies on Bering Island revealed traces of the expedition's encampment, artefacts from the shipwreck, and the physical toll the harsh conditions had taken on the men, adding a poignant material dimension to the historical record.

Although Bering himself wrote relatively little in the form of personal memoir, his official journals, reports, and navigational charts form a crucial part of the documentary legacy of his expeditions. These were carefully preserved in Russian archives and later studied by historians of exploration, providing insight into his methods and the organizational challenges he faced. Much of what is known about day-to-day events, wildlife observations, and interactions with

King George III: The King That Wasn't Mad?

George Levrier-Jones · History in 28 Minutes

Was King George III quite absurd or just misunderstood? Was he really the mad King that ruled like a tyrant or was he simply a man who succumbed to mental illness? If so, can we argue that he as an individual as well as his legacy have been misjudged and misconstrued?

The year is 1788. At Kew Palace. Inside the stone walls, a 50-year-old King George has descended into madness in the last few months. His behavior and mannerisms have shifted from calm and confident to agitated, angry and incoherent. The problem unclear, his family and five personal doctors are concerned. In their panic the King is placed into a mental asylum to be treated in secrecy. The question that concerns the monarchy is can the King be cured or will his legacy be overshadowed by his illness?

Sophie Riley explains.

George III. 1779 painting by Benjamin West.

The Crisis of 1788-89

By late 1788, the Kings decline could no longer be ignored what started as hours of endless monologues quickly turned into violent outbursts that ended in tearful fits. His Courtiers watched in alarm as they witnessed the decline of a man they once respected.

Doctors were quickly summoned but late 18th century medicine was ill equipped for curing mental illnesses. Some believed his blood had been poisoned which caused the king to have consistent bloodletting sessions, whilst others believed his mental decline was caused by his nerves and the rest blamed it on divine punishment. Alongside the bloodletting the additional treatments were severe and coldly dished out. In their desperation for the king's welfare, he was subjected to hours of isolation, physical restraints and blistering several doctors in the hope of shocking the King back to good health. None worked and he became a spectacle and a man to be feared by parliament and his own family.

As the Kings condition declined, the monarchy teetered on the brink. With the sovereign ill who would govern the country if the worst should happen? The Prince of Wales and his allies pushed for the Regency Bill to be drawn up, whilst the Kings hopeful ministers clung to a quick recovery. Britain however would have to watch in a state of desperation as their fate hung in the balance of a man's fragile mind.

As the King's health continued to decline, the news began to spread beyond the confinements of Kew Palace. His illness became a public spectacle. Britain in 1788 was nation of rumor where daily updates about the King's mental wellbeing spread like wildfire through tavern gossip and in the news bulletins. The caricature of the mad monarch pacing the palace grounds became a source of both pity and fascination by the public.

For ordinary citizens to see the king decline felt like a personal attack on their stability. Despite his legacy of madness King George III was a dutiful and conscientious monarch who made decisions for the good of his country. Despite his loss of America, he was a popular figure who brought stability in a time of industrial and social change. As well as being a dutiful monarch he was also a devoted family man who set an example for his wife, children, and his people. To see him unravel like this was to watch stability begin to shatter, some prayed for his recovery whilst others deemed this as a divine punishment for losing their colonies in America.

The media of the 18th century like now was unforgiving, Satirical artists seized an opportunity to dehumanize and degrade the King. Caricature images of George in deranged poses surrounded by his concerned family and attendants appeared daily. He was forever compared to the Flamboyant Prince of Wales who was portrayed as a saint waiting eagerly for power. These cruel yet compelling images shaped the public's imagination by reducing a complex human illness to a farce.

Parliament became a political battlefield in which the king's condition became ammunition for both sides. The Prince of Wales argued for immediate regency through establishing the Regency Bill, however the Kings cabinet insisted on patience and loyalty to the crown. George's health became a state emergency where every doctor's report and flicker of coherence were up for debate as if it were law. The monarchy during this time had never been so fragile.

Yet despite all the mockery and intrigue there was a quiet sympathy from those who served the King personally. Accounts from them speak of a man who was tormented by illness, a man who begged for forgiveness from his wife and children and above all this a sovereign who begged for empathy from those around him. In their eyes George was not mad but a tragic symbol of human fragility.

Medical Theories Then and Now

Medicine and science were still a mystery when King George's health declined. His physicians observed his erratic behavior and yet they had no framework to go off. The belief during the 18th century was to purge and shock the body into releasing the illness. Treatments were brutal and consisted of constant bloodletting and purging whilst being restrained. The Kings Doctors led by Francis Willis believed that a combination of strict control and moral discipline would restore their King.

Towards the end of the century, it seemed that the Kings health was improving as he began to recover and gradually return to his royal duties. His subjects, parliament and his family were both relieved and uncertain. Historians today are also stunned as some would argue that his recovery was miraculous, however modern historians believed that his illness had a cyclical nature and that the moments of clarity were followed by relapse. The mystery of King George's illness still baffles people today.

Cut out everything that's not surprising

Derek Sivers

This is my advice to anyone writing something for the public — especially a talk on stage.

People listen to a talk, or read an article, because they want to learn something new.

They want a little “oh wow” moment. “I never thought of it that way before.”

People only really learn when they're surprised.

If they're not surprised, then what you told them just fits in with what they already know. No minds were changed. No new perspective. Just more information.

So my main advice to anyone preparing to give a talk on stage is to cut out everything from your talk that's not surprising. (Nobody has ever complained that a talk was too short.)

Use this rule in all your public writing.

If you already found something surprising in what you're presenting, then remove everything else. If you haven't found something surprising about it yet, keep looking until you do.

What you learn by traveling

Derek Sivers

I wanted to learn about the world, so I went traveling.

People in the east are so graceful, I felt like an inconsiderate pig.

People up north are so serious, I felt like a lightweight clown.

People down south are so laid-back, I had to escape north again.

The way we define ourselves is all relative to our surroundings, right? However we differ from the people in our home town is how we define ourselves. That's where we shape our self-identity, growing up. Those are our defining traits.

But when we go to a different place, the relative comparisons collapse. Traits like speed, ambition, independence, bravery, and humor — they're all relative.

Back home I'm considered quiet. Here I'm considered loud.

Back home I'm a slacker. Here I'm a workaholic.

Back home I'm normal. Here I'm strange. Or vice-versa. So how do I define myself now?

I always want to know why a culture is this way. What's the difference? What are the core beliefs? So I ask questions and observe.

On the surface and from a distance, I see their actions. But deeply and closely, I see my reactions.

I want to learn about the world, so I keep traveling.

About the world, I learn a bit. About myself, I learn a lot.

IN BRIEF

Archivist, Medieval Archives: A Knight of the Seven Kingdoms Premiere Review — The Hedge Knight The world of Westeros opens a new chapter with A Knight of the Seven Kingdoms, a prequel set roughly a century before Game of Thrones and 72 years after House of the Dragon. The series begins on a rain-soaked, mud-slick morning as a lone man buries his fallen friend, a quiet, somber prologue that sets the tone for a very...

Source

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Source

BBC News, BBC News: Sir Andrew McFarlane welcomes the government backing for the change, saying it will turn the old approach “on its head”.

Archivist, Medieval Archives: Enter a vibrant medieval Europe – a sprawling sandbox of unrest, invasions, and alliances. Create a custom character and experience a path filled with conflict and opportunity. Chronicles: Medieval will evolve, shaping itself alongside community feedback into a living medieval playground – where no two stories are ever the same. Master medieval warfare with skill and strategy. Recruit...

Source

Royal Scribe, Medieval Archives: The holiday season has a habit of blurring boundaries. Time feels flexible, budgets feel forgiving, and entertainment often takes priority over structure. In gaming, this typically results in longer sessions, higher spending, and a willingness to experiment without much restraint. During December, this behavior is common and largely expected. Once the holidays end...

Source

Derek Sivers, Derek Sivers: I have so much more to say on this subject, but this book is done now because I believe short books are useful. So the conversation continues on the website:

sive.rs/u

There you will find more thoughts and stories around “Useful Not True”. Please email me any questions or thoughts. I reply to every one. Go to: book@usefulnottrue.com

Writing one sentence per line

Derek Sivers

My advice to anyone who writes: Try writing one sentence per line. I've been doing it for twenty years, and it improved my writing more than anything else.

New sentence? Hit [Enter]. New line.

Not publishing one sentence per line, no.

Write like this for your eyes only.

HTML or Markdown combine separate lines into one paragraph.

Why is it so useful?

It helps you judge each sentence on its own.

We sometimes write sentences that don't need to exist. Hidden in a paragraph, we might not notice. Standing on their own, we notice. Delete any sentence not worthy of its own line.

It helps you vary sentence length.

We need to vary the lengths of our sentences . Sometimes short. Sometimes long. Yes it really helps to read it out loud, but it's even clearer to see it on the page like this.

It helps you move sentences.

When all sentences are stacked in a column, they're easier to rearrange. Cut three lines. Paste them up

above. It's easier to move your best sentence to the beginning or end of a paragraph.

It helps you see first and last words.

First words punch. Last words linger. Seeing your sentences vertically helps you notice your beginnings and endings. Chop the weak beginnings, like "I think" and "Whether or not". Start with powerful subjects and verbs.

Heed your fears

Derek Sivers

People often ask me how they can get over their fears. For example, they are scared to quit their job and start a business. They want me to say something to make their fears go away. My advice is the opposite.

Pay attention to your fear. It often has good reason.

Don't get over it. Get under it.

Instead of ignoring fears, address them. Look deeper into what's inside them.

Address and mitigate the specifics.

Maybe you need to learn a little more. Look before you leap.

Always ask, "What's the worst that could happen?" Because sometimes the only problem was not realizing that the worst case scenario isn't bad at all.

But don't just tell yourself to get over it or ignore it.

Living according to your hierarchy of values

Derek Sivers

My “daily” blog was silent the last four days, because I took my kid on a spontaneous trip to another country. No phone . No computer. I gave him my full attention every day from when he woke me in the morning to when we fell asleep together at night. It was great.

I thought for a minute about the importance of my commitment to post here daily. But nope, being with him is more important than writing .

Upon returning, I considered heading off by myself on a 10-day trip, balancing writing and exploring another culture. But after sleeping on it , I realized that no, writing is more important than exploring .

Once you realize that one value is more important to you than another, you have to ask yourself if you’re living accordingly .

What’s ultimately more important to you?

Learning? Or creating?

Money? Or time?

Expanding? Or focusing?

(... etc.)

Once you know which takes top place, consider taking it to an extreme , to its logical conclusion, and optimizing your entire life around that top priority, letting go of almost everything else .

If the idea sounds unfulfilling, try re-ordering your priorities, and do the thought experiment again.

(That’s the subject of my next book, “ How to Live ”, which is my top writing priority right now, and so much fun!) ☺

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